

Module 1 · Start here

French pronunciation (vowels, silent letters, liaison)

How written French turns into sound — the rules that let you read any word.

YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

- ✓ Know which letters are silent
- ✓ Recognise nasal vowels and French-only vowels
- ✓ Apply liaison and elision

Spelling	Sound	Examples
an, am, en, em	[ɑ̃] (Quebec often closer to [ã])	enfant, temps, chambre, ensemble child, time, bedroom, together
on, om	[ɔ̃]	bon, nom, maison, nombre good, name, house, number
in, im, ain, ein, (y)en after i/é	[ɛ̃]	vin, important, pain, plein, bien, européen wine, important, bread, full, well, European
un, um	[œ̃] or [ɛ̃]	un, lundi, parfum a / one, Monday, perfume

Written	Said	What's silent
ils parlent they speak	[il paʁl]	-ent
les enfants the children	[le.zɑ̃.fɑ̃]	final -ts (the s of les is linked)
un petit garçon a little boy	[œ̃.pti.gasɔ̃]	final t, and the e of petit in speech
un sac, la mer a bag, the sea	[sak] [mɛʁ]	nothing — C and R are pronounced
six, dix six, ten	[sis] [dis]	said alone; before a consonant: six livres [si]

KEY PHRASES

Je voudrais un café.

I'd like a coffee. (five even beats, stress on -fé)

La fin de semaine, je travaille dans un restaurant.

On weekends, I work in a restaurant. (rise on -maine, fall on -rant)

un bon vin blanc

a good white wine (all four nasal)

Il est canadien. Elle est canadienne.

He's Canadian. She's Canadian. (nasal vs not)

Ils sont deux.

There are two of them. (no liaison: s-sound, not z)

Bonjour, je m'appelle Sara. J'habite à Montréal.

Hello, my name is Sara. I live in Montreal.

Tu as vu la rue où nous habitons ?

Did you see the street where we live? (u / ou)

Ils ont deux enfants, mais ils sont très occupés.

They have two children, but they're very busy.

Le poisson est délicieux, le dessert aussi.

The fish is delicious, the dessert too. (s / ss)

Elle arrive à huit heures avec Hélène.

She arrives at eight with Héléne. (enchaînement)

AVOID THESE MISTAKES

X Pronouncing the s in Paris, trois, vous

Saying final letters is the most common beginner error and can make words unrecognisable.

✓ **Final consonants silent (except C, R, F, L)**

X tu said like English "too"

"too" is tout (all) — a different word.

✓ **Lips rounded, tongue forward: [ty]**

X ils parlent with "-ent" pronounced

The verb ending -ent is always silent.

✓ **[il paʁl]**

X Pronouncing the h in hôtel

French h is never pronounced.

✓ **[otɛl], and l'hôtel**

X Stressing the first syllable: RES-aurant

English word stress makes French hard to follow.

✓ **Even syllables, stress at the end: res-tau-RANT**

X vous avez with a gap

Pronoun + verb liaison is obligatory.

✓ **vous avez [vu.za.ve]**

X je aime, le hôpital

Elision is compulsory before a vowel or mute h.

✓ **j'aime, l'hôpital**

TIP

Only the last syllable of each word group is stressed — never the first.

French pronunciation (vowels, silent letters, liaison): the rules at a glance

Lesson 1.1

CHEAT CODE Equal beats, stress at the end of the group

je

vou

drai

z_un

ca

fé
stressed

Every syllable gets the same length. Only the last one of the group is a little stronger.

Lesson 1.2

CHEAT CODE Pure vowels: lips and tongue hold still

u · tu, rue

say "ee", then round your lips

ou · tout, nous

"oo", very round, no glide

é · été, parler

short and tight, no "-ee" at the end

è · mère, lait

more open, like "bed"

Lesson 1.3

CHEAT CODE Three nasal vowels: the n / m is not said

an · en

[ɑ̃]

enfant

temps

chambre

on · om

[ɔ̃]

bon

nom

maison

in · ain · ein

[ɛ̃]

vin

pain

plein

Lesson 1.4

CHEAT CODE Consonants that trip English speakers

r

back of the throat, a soft gargle

h

always silent: l'hôpital

th

just t: le thé

ch

English "sh": chat

gn

"ny": montagne

s / ss

poison [z] vs poisson [s]

Lesson 1.5

CHEAT CODE What you don't say at the end of a word

Usually silent

s, t, d, x, z, p and -ent on verbs

Paris, petit, grand, ils parlent

vs

CaReFuL: said

c, r, f, l are usually pronounced

sac, mer, neuf, sel

Except -er: parler, premier — the r is silent.

Lesson 1.6

CHEAT CODE Three ways French links words

Liaison

a silent letter wakes up

les_amis

nous_avons

deux_heures

Élision

a vowel drops

le ami → l'ami

je ai → j'ai

Enchaînement

a sound slides over

il_a

une_amie